

AI Career LaunchPad — Self-Reflection Workbook

Complete this before your Career Compass session. Take your time — the quality of your report depends directly on the honesty and specificity of your answers. There are no right answers.

Block 1 — Your Career Depth

This block is about the expertise you have built over your career. The goal is to surface what makes you rare — not what your CV already says.

- 1. What is your primary domain — the industry or field where you have the most years and the highest seniority you reached?*

ANSWER: Electronics engineering and safety-critical automotive systems — spanning TRW, Brembo, Bentley and Pi Shurlok at senior and lead level over roughly 25 years.

- 2. What are 2–3 secondary domains where you have meaningful experience?*

ANSWER: Technical learning and academy management (Atmel Academy — global platform, 5000+ users, 40+ countries). Advanced HMI systems (Bosch Car Multimedia). Career coaching and Agile/Scrum coaching.

- 3. What specific problem types did you excel at repeatedly across your career? Not job titles — the actual type of challenge you were trusted with.*

ANSWER: Designing and scaling technical learning ecosystems at global level — curriculum architecture, content infrastructure, enablement at scale. Designing and validating systems where failure was not an option — functional safety, safety-critical embedded systems. Translating complex technical content into structured learning for non-specialist audiences. Bridging engineering rigour with human factors and usability.

- 4. Looking back across your career, what work did you do that involved data, patterns, optimisation, decision support, automation, or rule-based systems — even if it was never called AI at the time?*

ANSWER: Neural networks for welding parameter optimisation at Cranfield University in 1997 — MPhil in Welding and Robotics Technology. Rule-based and algorithmic systems in safety-critical automotive contexts. Decision support logic in HMI design. Pattern recognition in manufacturing quality control. Predictive modelling in welding robotics research.

5. *What is the single professional achievement you are most proud of? Describe it in 3–5 sentences. What does it reveal about what you do best?*

ANSWER: Building and running the Atmel Academy — a global technical learning platform serving over 5000 users across 40+ countries. Designed the curriculum architecture, managed the content and delivery infrastructure, and created a scalable model for technical enablement at international scale. The impact was measurable: engineers in 40+ countries changed how they worked with the technology because of how the learning was designed, not just because the content existed. This reveals that I do my best work when I am designing learning experiences that change behaviour at scale — not just informing people, but changing how they operate.

6. *Which subject areas, industries or problem types do you genuinely want to do more of — not out of obligation, but because they interest you?*

ANSWER: Designing and running AI enablement workshops and learning experiences — building capability in people and organisations, not just informing them. This is the work I find most energising: the moment a non-technical person understands what AI can actually do for them, because the learning was designed well enough to get them there. AI applied to safety-critical and regulated industries, where the stakes are real and the rigour matters. Building AI-powered products and systems that scale beyond a single engagement.

Block 2 — Your Working Style

This block is about how you actually operate — not how you think you should operate.

7. *Read the eight career anchors below and write your top 3 in order of importance to you:*
- *Technical/functional competence — being a deep expert in your field is central to who you are*
 - *General management — coordinating people, budgets and outcomes is what drives you*
 - *Security and stability — predictability, long-term employment and clear structure matter most to you*
 - *Autonomy and independence — you need to work on your own terms with minimal constraint*
 - *Entrepreneurial creativity — building something new from scratch energises you most*
 - *Service and dedication — the impact your work has on people is what gives it meaning*
 - *Pure challenge — you are most alive when the problem is genuinely hard and the outcome uncertain*
 - *Lifestyle integration — how work fits around your life and values matters as much as the work itself*

ANSWER: My top 3 anchors in order: *Entrepreneurial creativity, Pure challenge, Autonomy and independence*

8. *Do you do your best work alone, as part of a team, or leading a team? What evidence from your career supports that answer?*

ANSWER: Best work is done leading a team or working independently on complex problems — not as a peer contributor in a group. Evidence: built and ran Atmel Academy independently. Designed this project independently. Career coaching done one-to-one. Pattern is clear — I set direction and build, I do not wait for consensus.

9. *When working in a group, which role do you naturally gravitate toward?*
- *Driving the vision and direction*
 - *Making the technical solution solid and rigorous*
 - *Keeping people aligned and relationships working*
 - *Executing and getting things shipped*

ANSWER: Driving the vision and direction — consistently. Secondary role: making the technical solution solid and rigorous.

10. How do you operate when a project is genuinely complex and ambiguous — no clear brief, competing priorities, uncertain outcome? Be honest rather than aspirational.

ANSWER: Energised by it. The LaunchPad project itself is evidence — no brief existed, I identified the problem, designed the architecture and built it. Strategic thinking strengths cluster (Futuristic, Ideation, Strategic) means I naturally map from where things are to where they could be and work backwards to a plan. Tendency to move fast on the vision before all details are resolved — which is a strength and occasionally a risk.

11. What would you actively want to avoid in your next role — and why? The why matters more than the what.

ANSWER: Repetitive execution without creative input — because it produces slow resentment, not just boredom. Large corporate bureaucracy where decisions require multiple layers of approval — because my operating speed and autonomy need are incompatible with that environment. Being the person who maintains what someone else built — because my energy comes from origination, not maintenance.

12. Are you most comfortable working with technical peers, business and operational leaders, C-suite executives, or external clients? Where do you feel most credible and most energised?

ANSWER: Most credible and energised with C-suite and senior technical leaders — and with external clients in a consulting or advisory relationship. Least comfortable as a peer contributor in a large team with no clear ownership.

13. Are there things you are highly competent at that also drain you? List up to 3.

ANSWER: Detailed project administration and status reporting. Repetitive technical documentation without design input. Managing underperforming people through long performance processes.

14. Are there things you are still developing but that genuinely energise you? List up to 3.

ANSWER: Prompt engineering and LLM system design. AI workflow automation with n8n. Career architecture and transition strategy consulting.

Block 3 — The Bootcamp Layer

This block connects your nine weeks of intensive learning to your career transition. Be specific — "I liked the AI weeks" is not useful. "I spent three hours after class rebuilding the RAG pipeline because I wanted to understand the reranker" is.

- 15. Which weeks or topics during the bootcamp felt most energising? What specifically made them click — the type of task, the tools, the pace, the kind of output?*

ANSWER: The AI enablement design thinking — specifically how you take a complex AI capability and design a learning experience that makes it actionable for someone who has never touched it. The workflow automation weeks clicked fastest — n8n, LangChain and agent design — because building working systems from zero is how I learn. RAG pipelines and vector databases genuinely excited me at a technical level. But the moment I found most meaningful was when technical complexity became genuinely accessible through well-designed structure. The AI strategy and consulting weeks confirmed that the technical layer only has value when it connects to a real business problem someone actually has.

- 16. Which topics or subject areas did you excel at during the bootcamp — where did you feel genuinely competent, not just keeping up?*

ANSWER: System architecture and workflow design. Prompt engineering. Connecting technical capability to business problem framing. Presenting complex ideas clearly to non-technical audiences.

- 17. During project work, did you prefer working alone or in a group? What did you find yourself naturally doing — and what did you find yourself avoiding?*

ANSWER: Strongly preferred working alone or with clear ownership. When in a group, naturally took the architecture and direction role. Avoided being one of several people with unclear ownership of the same deliverable.

- 18. When working in a group during the bootcamp, which role did you assume? Was that the same role you tend to play in professional settings?*

ANSWER: Same role — vision, direction, architecture. Consistent with professional pattern.

- 19. How did your presentations go? Where did you feel confident and where do you think you fell short? What specific feedback did you receive and what would you do differently?*

ANSWER: Felt confident on content depth and narrative structure — Communication is a Clifton top 5 strength and it shows. Area to improve: managing time more tightly when the content is rich and the story is compelling. Tendency to go deeper than the slot allows.

20. What did the bootcamp confirm about yourself that you already suspected?

ANSWER: That I think in systems. That I find the intersection of technical depth and human impact more interesting than either alone. That I am a builder, not a maintainer.

21. What genuinely surprised you — something you discovered you were good at or enjoyed that you did not expect going in?

ANSWER: How quickly the n8n workflow design clicked — and how much I enjoyed the constraint of making things actually work end to end rather than just theorising about them.

Block 4 — The Transition

This block is about why you are here and what you are really after. The more honest you are, the more useful your Career Compass report will be.

22. Is this career move primarily a pull — genuine excitement about AI and what it opens up — or a push — industry pressure, redundancy risk, stagnation — or an honest combination of both? Be specific.

ANSWER: Primarily pull. AI is the first technology since neural networks in 1997 that I find genuinely intellectually interesting at a deep level — not just useful. The timing is also right: the bootcamp is the credential, LaunchPad is the proof of work, and the market is moving fast enough that a 25-year engineering background combined with AI implementation skills is a rare combination right now.

23. How much of your prior career identity do you want to carry forward? Some people want to be known permanently as "the engineer who now does AI." Others want to leave the old label behind entirely. Where do you sit?

ANSWER: Want to carry it forward deliberately — not as a label but as a differentiator. "The engineer who now does AI" is not the frame. The frame is "the person who has spent 25 years in safety-critical systems and now

applies that rigour to AI governance, implementation and strategy." The prior career is the moat, not the backstory.

24. What concern about this transition have you not said out loud yet — to a recruiter, a peer, or even yourself? Name it specifically. This field is used by the system to address that concern directly in your report, not to judge it.

ANSWER: That the market sees the career transition and defaults to offering a junior or mid-level role because the AI experience is new — discounting 25 years of senior engineering, global learning platform management and client-facing technical work. The concern is being mispriced, not being unqualified.

25. In one honest sentence — why are you making this move now?

ANSWER: Because the bootcamp gave me the technical language and implementation skills to make the transition credible, and because I built LaunchPad to prove it — to myself as much as to anyone else.

Block 5 — The Integration

This block asks you to start connecting old and new. Some of these questions may feel speculative — answer them as best you can. A hypothesis is more useful than a blank.

26. How does your prior career become a differentiator in AI consulting rather than something to explain away? What do you know, because of where you have been, that a recent graduate simply cannot replicate?

ANSWER: Safety-critical systems experience means I understand what it costs when AI fails in a regulated environment — not theoretically, but from years of working to standards where failure means liability, injury or death. A recent graduate cannot replicate that. It makes me a credible AI compliance and governance advisor in automotive, manufacturing and any regulated sector.

27. If you had to bet on one specific AI consulting niche where your background combined with your new skills creates something genuinely rare, what would it be?

ANSWER: Two niches, both anchored in the prior career, both in high demand right now. First: AI enablement and learning design for organisations scaling AI adoption internally — designing the programmes and experiences that change how people actually work with AI, not just

inform them. My background running Atmel Academy at global scale is directly applicable here, and most enablement consultants lack the technical depth to design learning that goes beyond surface-level tool familiarity. Second: AI compliance and governance consulting for regulated industries — specifically automotive and manufacturing — where my safety-critical systems background is a genuine differentiator.

28. What would you be happy doing every single day — not occasionally, not in theory, but as the core of your working week?

ANSWER: Running AI enablement workshops and designing learning programmes that change how organisations work with AI — with enough technical depth to go beyond the surface and enough autonomy to own the architecture of the learning experience. And consulting on the AI systems that underpin those engagements. Building things that scale beyond a single client: platforms, programmes, not one-off projects.

29. Remote, hybrid or in-person — what is your genuine preference, not your negotiating position?

ANSWER: Hybrid — primarily remote with regular client-facing work. Not open to five days in an office.

30. How much travel are you willing to do?

- *None — I need to be home based*
- *Occasional — a few days a month is fine*
- *Frequent — I am comfortable being on the road regularly*
- *Whatever it takes*

ANSWER: Occasional to frequent — comfortable being on the road for client work but not looking for a role that is travel-dominant.

31. Employed, freelance, or open to both? If freelance is on the table — do you have, or are you willing to build, the commercial infrastructure that requires: prospecting, proposals, client management, variable income?

ANSWER: Open to both — with a preference for freelance or fractional consulting if the pipeline can be built quickly, and employed if the role is senior enough and the autonomy is real.

32. What is your current timeline?

- *Active search — I need a role as soon as possible*
- *I have runway — I can afford to be selective and target the right role*
- *Stepping stone first — I am realistic that I may need a bridge role to build credibility before targeting my ideal position*

ANSWER: Active search — the bootcamp ends and LaunchPad needs a user.

Block 6 — Your Search Parameters

This block defines the practical constraints of your search. Be honest — these parameters shape which roles and opportunities LaunchPad will target for you.

Q33. What is your current timeline?

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ANSWER: Active search — I need a role as soon as possible

Q34. What is your employment and contract preference?

- *Permanent employed*
- *Contract / Fixed term employed*
- *Freelance / Project based*
- *Fractional / Part-time consulting*
- *Open to any*

ANSWER: Open to any

Q35. Are you willing to relocate?

- *Yes — open to relocation*
- *No — location fixed*
- *Possibly — depends on the role and conditions*

ANSWER: Yes — open to relocation

Q36. What are your preferred locations? List cities, regions or countries. If remote, say so here.

ANSWER: Braga district, Porto, Lisbon, Portugal, Europe, Oceania

Q37. What is your preferred working mode?

- *Remote*
- *Hybrid*
- *Presential*
- *Open to any*

ANSWER: Open to any

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